VTU MBA – FIRST SEMESTER

MANAGERIAL COMMUNICATION

MODULE 2: ORAL, LISTENING & NON-VERBAL COMMUNICATION

Expanded study notes | Definitions • Diagrams • Examples • Applications • Previous VTU questions

Course Code: 3MBA106 | Scheme: 2026 | Semester: I | Module Duration: 8 Hours

Syllabus coverage: Principles and modes of effective oral communication; conversation control, reflection and empathy; barriers and improvement strategies; listening approaches and process; classification and interpretation of non-verbal cues in professional contexts.

Reference basis: The supplied Module 2 notes identify P. D. Chaturvedi and Mukesh Chaturvedi as the primary reference, particularly Chapters 3 (Speaking Skills), 4 (Conversation Skills), 5 (Listening Skills) and 7 (Non-verbal Skills). The explanations below retain the source's terminology and structure, with additional examples and clarifications.

1. Oral Communication: Meaning and Nature

Oral communication is the exchange of spoken messages between a speaker and a listener. It involves expressing information, ideas, opinions, instructions or feelings through spoken words, supported by voice, tone and non-verbal cues.

It is generally immediate and interactive. The listener can ask questions, seek clarification and provide feedback while the conversation is taking place.

1.1 Characteristics of oral communication

- Immediate feedback: The speaker can observe the listener's response and clarify the message.
- Personal interaction: Voice, facial expression, posture and eye contact add meaning to spoken words.
- Flexibility: The speaker can change the explanation, examples or level of detail according to the listener.
- Speed: Simple information and urgent instructions can often be communicated quickly.
- Possibility of misunderstanding: Accents, noise, poor listening, emotion and ambiguous words may distort meaning.
- Limited permanent record: Unless recorded or documented, spoken messages may be forgotten or recalled differently.
- Context dependence: Meaning is influenced by the relationship, setting, culture and situation.

1.2 Oral and written communication

Basis	Oral communication	Written communication
Feedback	Usually immediate; questions can be answered at once.	Often delayed; clarification may require another message.
Record	No automatic permanent record.	Provides a record that can be stored and referred to.
Speed	Useful for urgent and interactive matters.	Useful when careful drafting and documentation are required.
Detail	Can explain through discussion and examples.	Can present complex information in an organized form.
Personal touch	Voice and non-verbal cues create personal contact.	Tone is conveyed mainly through word choice and formatting.
Best suited for	Discussion, coaching, negotiation, clarification and quick coordination.	Policies, formal instructions, contracts, reports and detailed procedures.

Neither form is universally superior. Managers select the medium according to urgency, complexity, need for interaction, audience, sensitivity and the need for a reliable record.

1.3 Managerial uses of oral communication

Use	Illustration
Instruction	A supervisor explains a revised production procedure to operators.
Coordination	Department heads discuss dependencies before a product launch.

Motivation	A manager recognizes team contributions during a meeting.
Problem-solving	A project team discusses the causes of a delayed delivery.
Persuasion	A manager presents the business case for a process improvement.
Negotiation	A buyer and supplier discuss price, quality and delivery terms.
Conflict resolution	A manager listens to both sides of a disagreement and helps agree on next steps.

2. Principles of Successful Oral Communication

Successful oral communication occurs when the speaker's intended meaning is understood by the listener and leads to an appropriate response. The supplied Chaturvedi-based notes emphasize purpose, lively rhythm, simple words, suitable pitch, sincere tone and body language, appropriate pace and fluency. Receiver orientation, precision and courtesy are also important practical principles.

Principle	Explanation	Workplace example
Purpose	Know why the message is being communicated and what outcome is expected.	Begin a meeting by stating whether the purpose is to inform, discuss or decide.
Lively rhythm	Use natural variation in pace and emphasis; avoid a flat or monotonous delivery.	Emphasize key deadlines and pause before an important point.
Simple words	Use familiar language and short, direct sentences.	Say “Submit the report by 4 p.m.” instead of using unnecessarily complicated wording.
Appropriate pitch	Adjust voice level and pitch to the audience, room and situation.	Speak clearly in a large meeting room without shouting.
Sincere tone and body language	Voice and physical behaviour should support the message.	Give corrective feedback calmly, with attentive posture.
Suitable pace	Speak neither too quickly nor so slowly that attention is lost.	Pause between the problem, evidence and recommendation.
Fluency	Present ideas in a connected and understandable sequence.	Explain a proposal in the order: need → options → recommendation.
Receiver orientation	Consider the listener's knowledge, needs, language and expectations.	Explain technical terms when addressing a non-technical client.
Precision	Be specific about facts, responsibilities, dates and actions.	State the owner, task and deadline rather than saying “finish it soon.”
Courtesy	Use respectful words and tone, even when disagreeing.	Challenge an idea with evidence without insulting its proposer.

2.1 Example of applying the principles

Unclear message: “Everyone should complete the pending work quickly.”

Improved message: “The finance team should verify the 12 pending invoices and upload the approved list to the shared folder by 3 p.m. on Friday.”

The improved message has a clear purpose, simple language, precise action, identified responsibility and a definite deadline.

Key point: Effective speaking is not merely speaking loudly or confidently. It is speaking with purpose, clarity, suitable delivery and consideration for the listener.

3. Modes of Oral Communication

Oral communication takes place through several modes. The choice depends on the number of participants, urgency, distance, complexity, confidentiality and need for feedback.

Mode	Typical use	Strength	Limitation
Face-to-face conversation	Coaching, feedback, problem-solving and sensitive discussions.	Immediate interaction; facial and other non-verbal cues are visible.	Can be affected by emotional reactions or an unsuitable setting.
Telephone/mobile call	Quick one-to-one coordination when people are apart.	Fast and convenient.	Visual cues are unavailable; details may need written confirmation.
Voice mail / voice message	Leaving information when the receiver is unavailable.	Asynchronous; receiver can listen later.	No immediate clarification; message may be missed.
Conference call	Coordinating people in different locations.	Connects several participants without travel.	Turn-taking and attention can be difficult.
Video conference	Remote interviews, reviews, meetings and presentations.	Combines spoken interaction with visual cues.	Depends on technology; distractions and connectivity problems may occur.
Meeting / group discussion	Decision-making, planning and coordination.	Brings multiple perspectives together.	May become unfocused without an agenda and facilitation.
Presentation / speech	Explaining or persuading a group.	Efficient for communicating a common message to many people.	Individual feedback during delivery may be limited.

3.1 Choosing an appropriate mode

A confidential performance discussion is usually better handled face-to-face or through a private video call than in a group meeting. A routine shift update may be communicated in a short briefing. A complex policy should normally be explained orally and supported by a written document.

3.2 Effectiveness of oral communication

Effective oral communication combines a clear message, suitable delivery, attentive listening, feedback, appropriate non-verbal behaviour and a desired outcome.

Element	What effectiveness looks like
Purpose	The intended outcome is clear.
Audience	The message matches the listener's knowledge and needs.
Message	The main point is easy to identify and understand.

Delivery	Pace, pitch, tone and fluency suit the situation.
Interaction	Listeners can ask questions and clarify doubts.
Non-verbal cues	Facial expression, posture and voice support the spoken message.
Feedback	The speaker checks whether the message was understood.
Outcome	The listener knows what to understand, decide or do.

4. Barriers to Oral Communication and Improvement Strategies

A barrier is any factor that prevents a spoken message from being delivered, received or understood as intended. The supplied notes identify poor listening as a major barrier and discuss language, status, receptivity and retention, along with emotional, contextual and cultural factors.

Barrier	How it affects communication	Example	Improvement strategy
Poor listening	The listener hears the words but does not attend to or process them.	An employee checks a phone while the manager explains a new procedure.	Remove distractions; invite questions; ask the listener to summarize key steps.
Language barrier	Words, accents, idioms or technical terms are misunderstood.	An engineer uses unexplained technical jargon with a customer.	Use plain language; explain unfamiliar terms; check understanding.
Status difference	A person may hesitate to speak openly to someone senior.	A junior employee notices a safety issue but remains silent.	Create a climate where questions and respectful disagreement are welcome.
Poor retention	Spoken details are forgotten, especially when many instructions are given rapidly.	A supervisor gives several task changes in one conversation.	Prioritize information and provide a short written recap.
Emotional state	Anger, fear, anxiety or defensiveness affects speaking and listening.	A manager gives feedback while angry.	Pause, regulate tone and focus on observable facts.
Vagueness	The listener has to guess what is expected.	“Complete it soon.”	Specify the task, owner, deadline and expected standard.
Wrong channel or setting	The environment or medium is unsuitable for the message.	A sensitive performance issue is discussed in a noisy corridor.	Choose a private and appropriate setting or channel.
Cultural differences	Different norms influence directness, silence, eye contact and turn-taking.	A direct statement is perceived as rude by one participant.	Avoid assumptions; observe, clarify and adapt respectfully.
Physical noise	External sound interferes with hearing.	A briefing takes place beside noisy machinery.	Move to a quieter area or use suitable audio equipment.
Information overload	Too many points reduce attention and recall.	A long announcement contains multiple unrelated instructions.	Organize the message into manageable points and check priorities.

4.1 Practical improvement strategies

- Prepare the purpose and key message before speaking.

- Choose a channel and setting appropriate to the importance and sensitivity of the matter.
- Use familiar words, short sentences and concrete examples.
- Encourage questions, clarification and respectful disagreement.
- Listen without interrupting and verify important points through paraphrasing.
- Control emotional reactions and avoid blaming language.
- Repeat or summarize critical instructions and document decisions where necessary.
- Be sensitive to language and cultural differences.

5. Conversation Control

Conversation control is the ability to guide an interaction towards its purpose while allowing the other person to participate. It is not domination of the conversation. It involves maintaining direction, responding constructively, noticing cues, asking relevant questions and bringing the discussion to a useful conclusion.

5.1 Important conversation-control skills

Skill	Meaning	Example
Control direction	Keep the discussion connected to the issue being addressed.	"Let us return to the delivery delay and identify its cause."
Manage negative responses	Respond calmly to resistance instead of escalating the disagreement.	Acknowledge the concern before explaining the decision.
Notice cues	Observe verbal and non-verbal signals such as hesitation, confusion or frustration.	Notice hesitation and ask whether any part needs clarification.
Interpret signs carefully	Consider context before deciding what a cue means.	Do not assume silence always means agreement.
Use sequential conversation	Build each response on what the other person has actually said.	"You mentioned cost. Which cost component is creating the difficulty?"
Summarize	Restate points of agreement and unresolved issues.	"We agree on the revised date; the staffing question remains open."
Assertiveness	Express a position clearly while respecting the other person.	"I disagree with this option because the data show a higher defect rate."
Timing	Raise a subject at a suitable moment and allow the other person to finish.	Discuss a sensitive concern in a private meeting, not during a public presentation.

5.2 Conversation-control sequence

LISTEN TO THE CUE → CLARIFY / REFLECT → RESPOND → LINK TO THE ISSUE → SUMMARIZE / MOVE FORWARD

The sequence keeps the interaction connected and purposeful. The speaker listens first, checks meaning, responds to the actual concern, returns to the issue and summarizes the way forward.

6. Parallel and Sequential Conversation

The supplied Chaturvedi material distinguishes parallel conversation from sequential conversation. The distinction is important because a conversation may contain many statements without participants actually responding to one another.

Parallel conversation	Sequential conversation
Each person pushes a separate statement or position.	Each response connects logically to what was said before.
Participants focus on proving their own point.	Participants try to understand and explore the issue.
Questions and clarification are limited.	Questions and reflection deepen understanding.
The discussion often becomes repetitive or reaches a deadlock.	The discussion is more likely to produce shared understanding and a decision.

6.1 Example

Parallel conversation:

Manager: “Customer complaints increased last month.” Sales: “We need more advertising.” Operations: “Our staff is already overloaded.” Sales: “Without advertising we cannot grow.” Operations: “Without more staff we cannot serve customers.”

The participants are defending separate positions. They are not examining the underlying problem.

Sequential conversation:

Manager: “What do the complaints tell us about the main problem?” Sales: “Some customers say the product is difficult to understand.” Operations: “We also see delays in responding to queries.” Manager: “So both product information and response time may be contributing. What evidence can we review first?”

Each response builds on the previous one and moves the discussion towards investigation and action.

7. Reflection and Empathy

Reflection means showing the speaker that their expressed meaning has been heard and understood. It often involves restating or paraphrasing the speaker's message in one's own words.

Empathy means attempting to understand another person's perspective or emotional position. It does not require agreeing with the person's opinion or accepting every conclusion.

7.1 Forms of reflective and empathic response

Response	Purpose	Example
Simple reflection	Restate the central meaning expressed by the speaker.	Employee: “I am worried about the deadline.” Manager: “You are concerned that the deadline may not be achievable.”
Clarifying response	Explore an incomplete or ambiguous statement.	“When you say the deadline is unrealistic, which dependency is causing the problem?”

Empathic response	Acknowledge the person's perspective or feeling.	“It sounds frustrating to be held to a deadline when the required data are still unavailable.”

7.2 Importance in managerial communication

- Reduces misunderstanding by checking whether the message has been interpreted correctly.
- Builds trust because the speaker feels heard and respected.
- Helps managers identify the actual concern behind a complaint or disagreement.
- Encourages employees to share problems, risks and suggestions.
- Supports constructive feedback, coaching, negotiation and conflict resolution.

Important distinction: Reflection checks the meaning of what was said; clarification explores what is unclear; empathy acknowledges the speaker's perspective or feelings. Empathy is not the same as agreement.

8. Listening as a Communication Skill

Hearing is the physical reception of sound. Listening is an active and deliberate process that involves attention, understanding, interpretation, evaluation and response. A person may hear a message without listening to it effectively.

Hearing	Listening
Primarily a physical process of receiving sound.	An active mental and interpersonal process.
Can occur without deliberate effort.	Requires attention and involvement.
Does not necessarily involve understanding.	Involves understanding and interpreting meaning.
Does not itself confirm that a message has been considered.	May include evaluation, empathy, clarification and response.

8.1 Importance of listening in management

- Decision-making: managers obtain information from employees, customers and other stakeholders.
- Problem identification: frontline employees may reveal process issues that do not appear in formal reports.
- Employee engagement: attentive listening communicates respect and encourages participation.
- Conflict resolution: listening helps identify interests and concerns behind opposing positions.
- Customer service: understanding customer needs improves the quality of responses.
- Learning and innovation: ideas and improvement suggestions can emerge from careful listening.

9. Approaches to Listening

The supplied notes emphasize thoughtful, responsive, reflective and clarifying approaches. Empathic listening is also closely connected to the conversation and listening concepts discussed in the reference material.

Approach / response	Focus	What the listener does

Thoughtful listening	Understand before reacting.	Gives attention, considers the message and avoids premature judgment.
Responsive listening	Show that the message is being received and considered.	Uses suitable verbal and non-verbal responses, such as brief acknowledgements and relevant follow-up questions.
Reflective response	Accurately mirror the speaker's expressed meaning.	Paraphrases the speaker's point instead of immediately advising or arguing.
Clarifying response	Draw out unclear, incomplete or ambiguous meaning.	Asks questions from the speaker's frame of reference.
Empathic listening	Understand the speaker's perspective and feelings.	Acknowledges the experience without necessarily agreeing with the speaker's conclusion.

9.1 Examples of listening responses

Speaker says	Useful listening response
“The new target is impossible.”	Reflective: “You feel the new target is too aggressive.”
“The process is not working.”	Clarifying: “Which step is causing the greatest difficulty?”
“I am tired of being blamed for delays.”	Empathic: “It sounds frustrating to feel held responsible for delays outside your control.”
“I have an idea to reduce rework.”	Responsive: “Please explain how the change would work.”

10. Process of Listening

The supplied Chaturvedi framework describes listening as a sequence of connected stages. Listening goes beyond hearing and includes interpretation, evaluation, empathy and the integration of what has been heard.

ATTENTION → HEARING → UNDERSTANDING → INTERPRETING → EVALUATING → EMPATHIZING → CONCEPTUALIZING

Stage	Explanation	Example in a workplace
Attention	The listener focuses on the speaker and reduces distractions.	A manager puts away the phone during an employee's explanation.
Hearing	The listener physically receives the spoken words and sounds.	The manager hears the employee describe a recurring production delay.
Understanding	The listener grasps the words, sentences and basic message.	The manager understands that the delay occurs during quality inspection.
Interpreting	The listener derives meaning by considering context, tone and prior knowledge.	The manager explores whether the delay is caused by staffing, equipment or process design.
Evaluating	The listener considers the relevance, logic and validity of the information.	The manager compares the explanation with production records.
Empathizing	The listener attempts to understand the speaker's point of view and feelings.	The manager recognizes the pressure experienced by the inspection team.
Conceptualizing	The listener assimilates the information into existing knowledge and forms an overall understanding.	The manager connects the issue to a wider process bottleneck and considers a process improvement.

The stages are presented in sequence for study, although real listening may involve movement back and forth between them. A listener may ask a clarifying question and revisit an earlier point.

10.1 Worked example

An employee tells a manager that customer orders are delayed because product specifications arrive late from another department. The manager gives attention, hears the explanation, understands the sequence of events, interprets the dependency, evaluates the information against order records, empathizes with the employee's difficulty and conceptualizes the issue as a cross-department coordination problem. The manager can then discuss corrective action with both departments.

11. Factors That Adversely Affect Listening

Factor	Meaning / effect	Illustration
Lack of concentration	Attention shifts away from the speaker.	A manager reads messages while an employee explains a customer complaint.
Unequal status	The listener may overvalue or dismiss a message because of the speaker's position.	A manager ignores a useful suggestion from a junior employee.
Halo effect	One positive or negative impression influences judgment of the entire person or message.	A well-liked employee's explanation is accepted without checking evidence.
Complexes / insecurity	Personal insecurity or self-image interferes with listening.	A manager interprets every question as a challenge to authority.
Closed mind	Ideas are rejected before they are fully understood.	A listener dismisses a new proposal because it differs from past practice.
Poor retention	Important details are forgotten.	A person forgets the second and third steps in a long verbal instruction.
Premature evaluation	The listener reaches a conclusion before the speaker finishes.	A manager interrupts after hearing only the first part of a problem.
Abstracting	The listener focuses on selected fragments and misses the overall meaning.	A listener remembers one criticism but misses the speaker's balanced feedback.
Slant / bias	Personal preferences or prejudices distort interpretation.	A manager gives more weight to information that supports an existing opinion.
Cognitive dissonance	Information that conflicts with existing beliefs creates discomfort and may be resisted.	A manager rejects evidence that a long-standing process is inefficient.
Language barrier	Unfamiliar words, accents or expressions reduce understanding.	A listener misunderstands an unfamiliar technical term.

11.1 How to become a better listener

- Give the speaker undivided attention and reduce avoidable distractions.

- Allow the speaker to complete the thought before responding.
- Listen to understand before evaluating, advising or defending a position.
- Observe facial expression, posture, gestures, tone and pitch as supporting cues.
- Ask clarifying questions instead of guessing at meaning.
- Paraphrase important points to verify understanding.
- Notice personal assumptions and separate facts from interpretation.
- Summarize decisions, responsibilities and action items at the end of the discussion.
- Use empathy when the conversation involves emotion, pressure or conflict.

11.2 The listen–reflect–clarify technique

Listen: Give full attention to the speaker. Reflect: Restate the central meaning. Clarify: Ask a focused question to resolve uncertainty.

Example: “You are saying that the current approval process is delaying dispatch. Which approval step creates the longest wait?”

12. Non-Verbal Communication: Meaning and Nature

Non-verbal communication refers to the communication of meaning through cues other than the literal words spoken or written. These cues may include facial expressions, gestures, posture, eye behaviour, voice qualities, appearance, use of space, silence and the use of time.

In professional communication, verbal and non-verbal signals usually operate together. Non-verbal behaviour may reinforce, modify or contradict spoken words.

12.1 Characteristics of non-verbal communication

- It can accompany spoken words and influence how they are interpreted.
- It may communicate attitudes, emotions, attention, confidence or discomfort.
- It can be deliberate or unconscious.
- Its meaning depends on the person, relationship, culture and situation.
- The same cue may have different meanings in different contexts.
- It can support or contradict verbal communication, but it is not a guaranteed method of reading another person's mind.

13. Classification of Non-Verbal Communication

The supplied Chaturvedi-based notes classify non-verbal communication under paralanguage, meta-communication, kinesics, grooming, proxemics and time language.

Category	Meaning	Professional example
Paralanguage	Vocal features accompanying words, such as pitch, loudness, tone, pauses, speed and speech fillers.	A hesitant “I think so…” may sound less certain than a clear, steady response.

Meta-communication	Implied meaning conveyed through the way a message is expressed, including tone, silence, emphasis, omission or context.	"Try to reach on time" may imply concern about repeated lateness, depending on context.
Kinesics	Body movements and expressions, including gestures, posture, facial expression and eye behaviour.	Nodding while listening may signal attention, though it does not prove full understanding.
Grooming / appearance	Dress, personal presentation and physical appearance as communication cues.	Professional attire may be appropriate for a formal client meeting.
Proxemics	Use of physical space and interpersonal distance.	Standing too close may make a colleague uncomfortable.
Time language / chronemics	Meaning communicated through the use and management of time.	Repeated lateness may be interpreted as low priority or disrespect, depending on context.

13.1 Paralanguage in detail

Paralanguage refers to how something is said rather than the literal words alone. Important elements include:

- Pitch: the highness or lowness of the voice.
- Volume: how loudly or softly a person speaks.
- Tone: the quality or emotional colouring of the voice.
- Rate: the speed of speech.
- Pauses: breaks that may provide emphasis or indicate hesitation.
- Fluency and fillers: smoothness of speech and expressions such as "um" or "er".

13.2 Kinesics in detail

Cue	Description	Caution in interpretation
Facial expression	Movements of the face that may convey emotion or reaction.	A smile can indicate friendliness, politeness, nervousness or other meanings.
Eye behaviour	Direction, duration and pattern of looking.	Eye contact norms vary across people, relationships and cultures.
Gestures	Movements of hands, arms or head.	A gesture should not be interpreted without considering context.
Posture	The way a person sits, stands or positions the body.	A posture may reflect comfort, fatigue, attention or the demands of the setting.
Body orientation	The direction in which a person faces or turns.	Turning away may have many explanations; it is not proof of disinterest.

13.3 Proxemics and professional space

Proxemics studies how people use physical space and interpersonal distance. Distance preferences vary by culture, relationship, task and individual comfort. A manager should respect personal space and consider the

setting—for example, a private coaching discussion requires a different arrangement from a formal presentation.

13.4 Time language

Time can communicate priorities and expectations. Punctuality, response time, meeting duration and respect for deadlines may influence how professionalism and consideration are perceived. However, delays can also result from workload, emergencies or other constraints; context matters.

14. Interpreting Non-Verbal Cues in Professional Contexts

Non-verbal cues should be interpreted as evidence to consider, not as certain proof of a person's thoughts or intentions. A manager should look for patterns, compare cues with the spoken message and seek clarification when necessary.

Situation	Possible cue	Careful managerial response
Employee appears hesitant during a briefing.	Long pauses, limited response or uncertain tone.	Ask whether any part of the instruction needs clarification; do not assume lack of competence.
Customer says the proposal is acceptable but speaks hesitantly.	Words and tone may not fully align.	Ask whether any concern remains and invite specific feedback.
Team member is silent in a meeting.	Silence may reflect reflection, uncertainty, status concerns or cultural norms.	Invite input without putting the person under pressure.
Colleague repeatedly checks the clock.	May indicate a time constraint or competing commitment.	Ask whether the meeting needs to be shortened or rescheduled.
Remote participant has camera off.	Could reflect connectivity, privacy or personal circumstances.	Use verbal check-ins rather than assuming disengagement.

14.1 Verbal–non-verbal congruence

Situation	Possible interpretation
Words and tone agree.	The message is more internally consistent.
Words say “I am calm” but voice and body show agitation.	The receiver may question whether the verbal claim reflects the speaker's actual state.
A manager says “Please continue” while repeatedly looking at the clock.	The words invite the speaker to continue, while the behaviour may suggest time pressure or impatience.

Important caution: Avoid treating a gesture as a universal code. Non-verbal cues vary by person, culture, relationship and situation. The popular 7–38–55 formula associated with Mehrabian should not be generalized as a rule for all communication.

15. Integrated Case Studies

Case 1: The Missed Instruction

A manager explains a new inventory process during a busy shift. An employee nods throughout the explanation. The next day, the employee follows the old process and says, “I thought you meant only the weekend stock.”

Analysis: A nod is not sufficient proof of complete understanding. Background noise and divided attention may have affected listening. The manager could have explained the change in a quieter setting, invited questions and asked the employee to restate the new process. A short written recap could reinforce the oral instruction.

Case 2: Parallel Conversation in a Team Meeting

A manager reports that customer complaints have increased. Sales argues that more advertising is needed. Operations says that staff are already overloaded. Sales repeats that advertising is essential for growth, while Operations repeats that more staff are needed. The meeting ends without a decision.

Analysis: This is parallel conversation because participants defend separate positions rather than exploring the underlying issue. The manager could reflect both concerns, ask what evidence supports each view and guide the group towards a sequential discussion.

Case 3: The Interviewer Who Does Not Listen

An interviewer asks a candidate a question, checks a laptop while the candidate answers, interrupts after 20 seconds and asks a different question that the candidate has already addressed.

Analysis: The interviewer displays poor concentration, interruption and premature evaluation. The non-verbal behaviour may communicate low interest and discourage the candidate from sharing information. The interviewer should listen fully, take brief notes, use appropriate eye behaviour and ask relevant follow-up questions.

Case 4: Words and Behaviour Do Not Match

During a project review, a manager tells an employee, “Please take your time and explain the issue.” At the same time, the manager repeatedly checks a phone and looks towards the door. The employee gives a very brief explanation and leaves out important details.

Analysis: The manager's verbal invitation and non-verbal behaviour send inconsistent signals. The employee may infer that the manager is not available to listen. The manager should remove distractions, give the employee attention and clarify whether there is enough time for the discussion.

16. VTU Previous / Model Questions

The supplied Module 2 notes include the following historical and model-paper questions. They are retained here as questions reported in the source notes; they are not predictions of the current 2026 examination pattern.

Source identified in supplied notes	Question / topic	Marks
VTU 2018-scheme, January 2019	What is conversation control?	3
VTU 2018-scheme, January 2019	Briefly discuss the difference between good listeners and poor listeners.	7
VTU 2018-scheme, January 2019	Managers experience various barriers. Briefly describe the barriers to oral communication.	10
VTU 2020-scheme model paper	What is listening?	3
VTU 2020-scheme model paper	"Non-verbal communication speaks louder than words." Comment.	10
VTU 2020-scheme model paper	Explain the principles of oral communication.	7
VTU July/August 2022	Briefly explain the principles of successful oral communication.	7
VTU 2016/17 paper (indexed copy)	What is non-verbal communication?	2
VTU 2016/17 paper (indexed copy)	Mention the 7 Cs of successful communication.	8

Question-paper caution: The questions above belong to earlier schemes or model papers as identified in the supplied notes. The current 2026 syllabus is Course Code 3MBA106. Use historical questions to identify recurring concepts, not as a guarantee of future questions.

17. Additional Practice Questions

Marks	Practice questions
3	Define oral communication.
3	What is conversation control?
3	Differentiate hearing and listening.
3	What is reflective listening?
3	Explain empathy in communication.
3	Define non-verbal communication.
7	Explain the principles of successful oral communication with examples.
7	Explain the barriers to oral communication and suggest suitable remedies.
7	Differentiate oral and written communication.
7	Explain conversation control and its importance in managerial communication.
7	Explain the approaches to effective listening.

7	Differentiate parallel and sequential conversation with examples.
10	Explain the process of listening with a neat diagram.
10	Explain the classification of non-verbal communication with suitable examples.
10	Discuss the factors that adversely affect listening and explain how listening can be improved.
10	Explain the role of reflection and empathy in effective managerial conversations.
10	Discuss how managers can interpret non-verbal cues in professional contexts.

18. Quick Revision Sheet

Topic	Key points to remember
Oral communication	Exchange of spoken messages; immediate, interactive and supported by feedback and non-verbal cues.
Principles	Purpose, lively rhythm, simple words, pitch, sincere tone/body language, suitable pace, fluency, receiver orientation, precision and courtesy.
Modes	Face-to-face, telephone, voice mail, conference call, video conference, meeting/discussion and presentation.
Barriers	Poor listening, language, status, retention, emotion, vagueness, wrong setting/channel, cultural difference, noise and overload.
Conversation control	Direction, negative responses, noticing cues, sequential responses, summarizing, assertiveness and timing.
Parallel conversation	Participants repeat or defend separate positions.
Sequential conversation	Each response connects to the previous contribution and explores the issue.
Reflection	Restates the speaker's expressed meaning.
Clarification	Explores incomplete or ambiguous meaning.
Empathy	Acknowledges the speaker's perspective or feelings; does not mean agreement.
Listening process	Attention → hearing → understanding → interpreting → evaluating → empathizing → conceptualizing.
Listening barriers	Concentration, status, halo effect, complexes, closed mind, retention, premature evaluation, abstracting, bias, dissonance and language.
Listening improvement	Attention, no interruption, clarification, paraphrasing, awareness of bias, empathy and summarizing.
Non-verbal classification	Paralanguage, meta-communication, kinesics, grooming, proxemics and time language.
Interpretation	Cues may reinforce or contradict words; meaning is contextual, not universal.

19. References and Scope Note

Primary reference basis: P. D. Chaturvedi and Mukesh Chaturvedi, Business Communication: Skills, Concepts, and Applications, Pearson, 2018, particularly the chapters identified in the supplied notes: Chapter 3 – Speaking Skills; Chapter 4 – Conversation Skills; Chapter 5 – Listening Skills; Chapter 7 – Non-verbal Skills.

Syllabus basis: VTU MBA 2026 Scheme, Course Code 3MBA106, Semester I, Module 2 – Oral, Listening & Nonverbal Communication (8 hours).

The core terminology and classification are retained from the supplied Module 2 notes. Workplace examples, explanatory comparisons, cases and revision tables are expanded teaching material. Historical VTU questions are reproduced as identified in the supplied notes; their scheme/year labels have been retained.

The 2026 syllabus scope is prioritized. Topics beyond the specified Module 2 scope have not been added as separate units.